

"Probiotics are essential for good gut health and the traditional Indian diet has many sources like curd and various fermented vegetables"

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fats are a modern phenomenon," says noted endocrinologist Dr S.K. Mishra. In 2019, a University of Oxford study of 400,000 food and drink products in 12 countries published in *Obesity Reviews* found those in India to be the least healthy, with high levels of saturated fat, sugar and salt. Our packaged food and drinks were the most energy-dense, with an average of 1,515 kJ and 7.3 gm of sugar per 100 gm.

As Mohan points out, despite the growing realisation among Indians about the need to eat healthy, "there is still a large amount of dependency on packaged foods and very poor nutritional literacy". That is one reason India's salt consumption has gone up, simply because we do not know how much salt there is in a packaged product. "We try to educate many patients in the hospital," says Samaddar. "A lot of our packaged foods are extremely high in salt. Even cooking sauces and dressings." A 2016 study of 5,796 packaged food products in India by the George Institute for Global Health, Public Health Foundation of India and the Centre for Chronic Disease Control in India, found excessively high levels of salt. Don't be fooled by that humble papad, a staple on the Indian plate—it has a mean sodium content of 1,219 mg per 100 gm. Some products have a sodium content of 4,000 mg per 100 gm. And the American Heart Association recommends an intake of under 2,300 mg a day!

We need to worry about the health implications of packaged foods because Indians are snacking more than ever before. The cruellest are the ultra-processed packaged foods, which the British Heart Foundation defines as those that have a long shelf life and generally have five or more ingredients, including but not limited to, preservatives, emulsifiers, sweeteners and artificial colours and flavours. In India, this sector has grown at a compound annual growth rate of 13.4 per cent in retail sales value from 2011 to 2021, as documented by a WHO-ICRIER report this year. Among the five popular categories are chocolate and sugar confectionery, salty snacks, beverages, readymade and convenient foods and breakfast cereals.

The study recommended that the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), in consultation with other stakeholders, come up with a clear definition of High in Fat, Sugar and Salt (HFSS) food. They also recommended a nutrient-based tax model, with higher amounts for products with fat, sugar and salt above recommended limits, noting that such models have had public health benefits in countries where they have been implemented.

"We have noted the increase in intake of HFSS food and are acting on it," says FSSAI chairman G. Kamala Vardhana Rao. In September last year, the food safety regulator had proposed a nutrition rating system on packages. Products would be rated on a nutritional profile of one to five, giving buyers quick and easy information about the food they consume. "We have received over 14,000 industry responses and are going through them," says Rao.

While the idea has faced strong opposition from many manufacturers, consumers themselves are not averse to such labelling. A 2023 study by LocalCircles of 19,000 respondents in India found that 77 per cent did not mind a front-of-the-pack label on ultra-processed foods, though they preferred it to be colour-coded rather than numerical. Some large companies are already bowing to the trend. "We are investing in more nutritious offerings, including adding ingredients like whole grains, vegetables and micronutrients to our products," says a Nestlé India spokesperson. "Nestlé India voluntarily has on the front of the pack a Guideline Daily Amount (GDA) labelling system that provides consumers transparent nutrition information in the context of a reference portion for energy and other key defined nutrients in relation to their daily needs." Says Bhasin of ITC, "According to FSSAI guidelines, we already mention calorie counts for all our dishes on the menu."

The government, too, has expanded its Eat Right Campaign, which aims to educate the public on healthy and mindful eating habits through school programmes, internet pamphlets, eating fairs and healthy eating certifications to hotels. Millets were also a part of the menu at the meals served during the recent G20 summit. It's a win-win situation. Eat right, and you keep your weight in check, disease at bay, and simply live longer. ■

–with Aditi Pai, Chumki Bharadwaj and Shelly Anand